

the world and it did. I am really glad that everyone invested in the concept,” former BCCI secretary and incumbent ICC chair Jay Shah said in 2023. Expansion will take time, but individual players have already benefited immensely from the league’s visibility. JSW Sports, which manages Jemimah Rodrigues and Shafali Verma in addition to representing the Delhi Capitals franchise, says Jemimah’s brand value has risen from Rs. 60 lakh to Rs. 1.5 crore, while Shafali’s has climbed from Rs. 40 lakh to Rs. 1 crore. Beyond commercial gains, the WPL has offered an alternative path for players. Like the Women’s Big Bash League, the now-defunct Kia Super League and The Hundred, it provides a platform for careers even without the India shirt.

With the auction set to take place weeks after the World Cup and many World Cup winners back in the pool, bidding dynamics may shift too.

Watershed moment

India’s famous triumph in Navi Mumbai to clinch its first ICC women’s trophy triggered a commercial surge in the weeks that followed. Beyond significant cash awards and personal incentives, a wave of endorsements arrived. Harleen Deol landed a campaign with Lakme, integrating it with the conversation she had with the Prime Minister at his residence. Renuka Singh Thakur and Jemimah shot an ad for fast-food giant KFC the very next day. Surf Excel capitalised on Jemimah’s muddled semifinal jersey (pic, right) with a full-page ad using its “*Daag achhe hain*” tagline. Hours after the final, skipper Harmanpreet Kaur was announced as ambassador for real estate enterprise Omaxe.

“It’s become pretty close to a dangerous position where cricket is almost a product rather than an event,” image guru Dilip Cherian tells *Sportstar*.

“Men’s cricket is sliced and diced in so many ways. The women’s game is just entering that arena, thanks to three key developments: a big win in front of high-energy crowds, consumers’ ability to identify favourites by name, and the backing of funds by the system itself, like prize money, which we saw in this World Cup,” he adds.

Alongside marquee names like Smriti, Harmanpreet and Jemimah, the World Cup win thrust others into the spotlight. From Shafali and Deepti Sharma to Sneha Rana and Pratika Rawal, players have received endorsement deals, speaking engagements and television appearances.

“The huge advantage now is that a new batch of female heroes has entered the market at price points that are more affordable as well. The temptation to experiment at reasonable costs will be acted on by brands. I only hope players and industry players don’t fall for the easy route of sticking with cosmetics and household appliances,” says Cherian.

Across advertising, public relations and even journalistic spaces, target audiences are shifting. Women’s sports and female icons are no longer perceived as relevant only to women, and Cherian sees the industry recognising this change.

“It was not an all-female crowd at the D. Y. Patil Stadium on November 2. A crowd, largely male, came to watch their heroes do something incredible. Viewership numbers also suggest the same.”

Building bridges

The final between India and South Africa attracted 185 million users on *JioHotstar*, drawing a peak concurrency of 21 million viewers. This matched the viewership of the Men’s T20 World Cup 2024 final between the same nations and exceeded the average daily reach of the Indian Premier League.

The tournament recorded a reach of 446 million, the highest ever for women’s cricket and more than the combined total of the previous three Women’s World Cups. Ninety-two million watched the historic clash on connected TV, matching the connected TV viewership of the Men’s T20 World Cup 2024 final and the Men’s ODI World Cup 2023 final.

It is no surprise, then, that several WPL teams anticipate a 40 to 60 per cent rise in player valuations, particularly for top performers.

While commercial gains have brightened the ecosystem’s surface, Nandan Kamath, co-founder and managing trustee of the GoSports Foundation, stresses the importance of strengthening its foundations.

“Success is such an important driver of a belief system, right? And the highest value is not just in spectatorship or commercials, but what it does for the micro conversations that happen around sports,” he tells *Sportstar*.

“That includes young girls speaking to their parents about sport, an academy owner deciding whether to accommodate girls in his establishment. Academies are often set up with low infrastructure and can be quite unfriendly to girls in aspects like washrooms, safety, etc. Kit producers can now think of tuning equipment for women better. Success can make discussions that were marginal more mainstream.”

A tier up, the BCCI’s age group tournaments for women have also become more regular in the years since the pandemic. A U-19 World Cup held every two years, which India has already won twice, helps keep boards alert and provides a clear incentive to maintain a steady talent pipeline.



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